

Gozo salt pans, a tradition with little vision for a future

By Kaya Equevilley

The Xwejni Salt Pans are a popular tourist destination on the island of Gozo where salt is harvested by hand, a tradition that might soon disappear.

On the northern coast of Gozo in a town called Xwejni, 350 year old salt pans cover roughly 3 km of coastline. Gozo is an island that is part of the Maltese archipelago, located in the mediterranean sea. These salt pans are historically significant for the production of Gozitan sea salt production. The way Gozitans harvest salt dates back to the Phoenician era, with changes and adaptations throughout the years as new techniques have developed.

There are three remaining salt farms on the north coast of Gozo. “I have trouble, I want to leave the farm for my sons and daughter but they have a lot of work, and don’t have time,” said Attard. Alfred Attard, a 70-year-old salt farmer said that there is no one able to take over the farm after he and his wife pass.

The harvest season is May through September. During this time, Attard will harvest once a week if the weather is average. An average week in the summer will produce 3 tons of salt, all of which is carried by Attard. He took the farm over from his wife Mary Attard’s late father, in order to carry on her family work.

The process which transforms salt water into salt is called the evaporation method. In this method, a body of salt water sits in a specific pool for 7 - 10 days. Then it is transferred to a smaller pan where it will sit for 5 days during average summer weather. During this time the water evaporates, the brushing and collecting process follows. Once the salt is collected into buckets, the Attard’s hand cleans the salt in preparation to be packaged and sold.

The natural sea salt that is harvested will be sold for €2 to €12. It may also be delivered on foot to local restaurants and farmers. The salt from these farms can also be found in local markets and grocery stores.

There are two alternative methods to producing salt, mining and the use of artificial heat. The mining method collects naturally grown rock salt through excavation methods. The artificial heat method allows man made salt water to undergo a process similar to the evaporation process in order to extract the salt particles.

The salt pans on the northern coast of Gozo island are used for traditional harvest practices. The harvest season begins in May and runs through September.

During the off season farmer owned salt shops across from the salt pans may remain open, though it is difficult to maintain a staff said salt farmer Alfred Attard on April 8.



Attard touches newly formed salt on April 8.

When the salt water evaporates in the pan it leaves the salt behind. The salt is brushed into a pile and transported inside his shop for cleaning.

70 year old Alfred Attard is the only one who farms his 600 pan salt farm. In the summer he carries about 3 tons of salt a week. His 66-year-old-wife, Mary Attard, is too weak to farm now.



Navigating through the salt pan farm, Attard carries the brush and scoop to collect the salt on April 8.

With over 50 years of experience, Attard is concerned no one will continue the family business once he and his wife pass away.

“There are too many salt pans, too much work,” said Attard.



The salt water sits in the sun in the smaller pan. The salt that remains after evaporation is brushed into a pile and transferred in a bucket on April 8.



Attard collects all of the salt into piles and moves it to a bucket on April 8.

Attard will attach 2 to 10 buckets on a carrying pole and walk the buckets inside on his shoulders. Usually he goes through this process once a week. When it is abnormally warmer, he will harvest every 3 days.



On the walk back to the shop to clean the salt, Attard greets observers that watch as he harvests the salt on April 8.

This shop has been in his wife's family for over 100 years.

Attard has been a salt farmer for 50 years. Before he and his wife married he was a traditional farmer. Then he worked with cows, chickens and other livestock.



Attard dumps the salt from the harvest into the salt room on April 8.

At the end of the summer harvest Attard fills a room to the ceiling with salt. That salt lasts them until the next season.

Attard said that there are two other farmers and one farm is close to closure because the farmer is ill and has no one to take over.



Attard sits on a stool while he hand combs through the salt, picking out excess pieces on April 8.

The last step in the harvest process is to clean the salt.

Alfred Attard said as he continues to age, it is harder to clean as efficiently as he once did.



Alfred Attard holds sea salt that he harvested last summer on April 8. This salt will be packaged and sold to shops, restaurants and farmers.



Natural Xwejni sea salt farmers, Alfred and Mary Attard sit in their shop across from the salt pans on April 8.

The Attards sell their salt in a variety of ways. They sell in local markets, local stores, online, and in their shop.



On the southern end of Malta's mainland, at the Marsaxlokk fish market Gozo sea salt is sold on April 6.

"I had no idea that you could harvest salt like that," said Cynthia Collins.

Collins is from the United Kingdom and plans to stay in Malta for four days on vacation. She heard about the natural salt harvest from her hotel receptionist.



Natural Xwejni sea salt farmer Alfred Attard demonstrates how the natural sea salt harvest occurs on April 8.

